Indigenous Peoples of Canada



History, heritage, and reconciliation

Do Indigenous people only live in the past?





LOOK · THINK · DISCUSS

Look at the two images.

What do you see? What is different? What do you think the lesson is about?

Match the word to the definition

WORK IN PAIRS

Match each word with a definition.

1. Indigenous
2. Treaty
3. Residential school
4. Reconciliation
5. Heritage

Definitions

- A. A formal agreement about land or peace
- B. Building a good relationship again after conflict
- C. Traditions, languages, and culture passed through generations
- D. The original inhabitants of a land
- E. A school where children were separated from their families

Five words we need today

Read the words. Explain them in your own language.

Indigenous

Original inhabitants of a land.

Treaty

A formal agreement between groups.

Residential school

A school where Indigenous children were forced to live, separated from their families.

Reconciliation

Making peace and building a good relationship again.

Heritage

Traditions, languages, and culture passed through generations.

Reading check: put the events in order

Number these events from 1 (first) to 4 (last).

1. The government apologized for residential schools.
2. European settlers arrived and made treaties.
3. Indigenous peoples lived in North America.
4. Children were forced to attend residential schools.

Canada’s story in four moments



Before European arrival:

First Nations, Inuit, and Métis lived in North America with complex societies, languages, and cultures.

17th–18th centuries:

European settlers arrived and made treaties, but many promises were later broken.

1870s–1990s:

The government forced Indigenous children to attend residential schools, causing deep trauma and loss of heritage.

2008 and today:

The government apologized; reconciliation means working to heal relationships with Indigenous communities.

THE BIG IDEA

What does reconciliation mean?

Read the quotes. What do they ask us to think about?

“Reconciliation is not about the past. It is about the future.”

“We must learn the truth before we can heal.”

“Our heritage is not dead. It is alive in our youth.”

Discuss: What do these quotes mean? Why must a country learn the truth? How can a country heal historical trauma?

Group task: become museum curators

Create a concept for an exhibition called “Reconciliation in Canada”.

01

Exhibition title

Write a strong exhibition title.

02

Key idea

Choose the key idea visitors should remember.

03

Visitor rules

Write three rules for visitors: what should they think about while viewing the exhibition?

04

Presentation

Prepare a short presentation for the class.

Dialogue of cultures

Discuss in small groups.

LISTEN RESPECTFULLY

01

Past experiences

Does your country have Indigenous or minority groups that suffered in the past?

02

Remembering

How does your country remember or teach about them?

03

Learning

What can we learn from Canada's experience with reconciliation?

Compare experiences, not people.

EXIT QUESTION

Why is it important to learn about the history of Indigenous people?

Answer in one or two clear sentences.

HOMEWORK

Write about 50 words

“Why is reconciliation a difficult but important process for any country?”